

Unit 6 Part B — Writing a One-sided Argumentative Essay

1. Purpose & example questions

Purpose

- To express your opinion on a **controversial** issue, arguing either for or against it
- Target audience — **students** (on the school newsletter), the **general public** (on newspapers and technology magazines)

Example questions

- *Social media does more harm than good to teenagers.*
- *Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?*
- *Is the internet making us less able to concentrate?*

2. Planning your essay

Title	Choose ONE of three patterns: (1) Issue + verdict — <u>Social Media: More Harm Than Good</u> (2) Question — <u>Is Social Media Doing More Harm Than Good?</u> (3) Call to action — <u>Why We Must Rethink Social Media</u>
Introduction	1. Hook — one striking line, figure, image or short question <i>The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media.</i> 2. Narrow the focus — link the issue to the audience <i>Social media is now ubiquitous and it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another.</i> 3. Stance — ONE side, in one sentence <i>I firmly believe that ... / It is undeniable that ...</i>
Body paragraphs 1 & 2	1. Topic sentence — a signpost + the argument itself <i>First and foremost, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health.</i> 2. Explain — build a cause-and-effect chain (X → Y → Z) <i>Platforms are designed to reward comparison, so users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's lives, and they are encouraged to measure their own against them.</i> 3. Example — Findings / Real-world case / Typical process <i>Findings — "According to the US Surgeon General's 2023 advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on</i>

	<i>social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety."</i> <i>Real-world case — France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a "digital pause", requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. (Another: in November 2024, Australia legislated a minimum age of sixteen for social media accounts.)</i> <i>Typical process — Consider what happens when the app is opened for a five-minute break: the feed fills with classmates' holidays and prizes, an ordinary evening is set beside them, and self-doubt follows.</i> Never write these (a marker spots them instantly) • invented names ("my friend Jason", "a Form 5 student called Mary") • invented percentages ("87% of students") 4. Round off — echo your topic sentence <i>Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates the anxiety that many teenagers already carry.</i>
Body paragraph 3 (counter-argument & rebuttal)	1. Concede — state the other side briefly <i>Admittedly, ... / Some may argue that ...</i> 2. Rebut — a concrete reason why the objection fails <i>However, this argument overlooks the fact that ...</i> 3. Round off — re-affirm your stance <i>Put simply, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm compounds year after year.</i>
Conclusion	1. Restate the stance in NEW words — do not copy the introduction 2. Summarise your arguments in one line. 3. Final thought — a call to action.

3. Practice - Complete the following writing plan	
Question: <i>Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?</i>	
Your stance: <i>Affirmative / Negative</i>	
Title	Suggested answers — the plan below argues the AFFIRMATIVE side: schools should ban AI chatbots from the classroom. Issue + verdict — AI Chatbots in the Classroom: More Harm Than Good Also acceptable: Should Chatbots Do Our Thinking? (question) · Why Schools Must Rethink AI Chatbots (call to action)
Introduction	Hook — Within seconds, a chatbot can produce the paragraph a student was supposed to write. Narrow the focus — These tools are now the fastest-spreading presence in the classroom, and their promise of instant answers is changing what students do with their minds. Stance — I firmly believe that schools should ban AI chatbots from the classroom.
Body paragraph 1	Topic sentence — First and foremost, chatbots are detrimental to students' thinking. Explain — Because a chatbot hands over a finished answer, students skip the struggle of building one; the effort that turns information into understanding is replaced by copy-and-paste, and the habit of thinking for oneself is stifled. Example (real-world case) — In January 2023, New York City's education department blocked ChatGPT on school networks and devices, explaining that it "does not build critical-thinking and problem-solving skills". Round off — When the answer arrives before the thinking, the thinking never happens.
Body paragraph 2	Topic sentence — Moreover, allowing chatbots in the classroom erodes the value of every piece of assessed work. Explain — If an essay, a report or a set of short answers can be generated in seconds, a teacher can no longer tell what a student actually understands; marks stop measuring learning, and the students who work honestly are the ones who lose out. Example (real-world case) — In January 2023, Sciences Po in Paris barred students from submitting AI-written work without transparent referencing, treating uncited AI text as academic fraud. Round off — An essay that can be generated is an essay that no longer measures anything.

Body paragraph 3	Concede — Some may argue that chatbots give weaker students instant explanations and help them catch up. Rebut — However, an explanation obtained without effort is rarely remembered: understanding is built by struggling with a problem, not by receiving its solution, and a tool that does the thinking cannot build the thinker. Round off — Put simply, a shortcut in learning is not a shortcut to learning.
Conclusion	Restate the stance — A classroom where answers can be generated on demand is no longer a place where learning is measured. Summarise — Chatbots weaken thinking and make assessment meaningless, and the convenience on offer is not worth that price. Final thought — Schools need not fear the technology, but they should keep it out of the work that shows what students can do alone.

4. Sample writing Question: You have read an article in a local technology magazine claiming that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Write an essay for the magazine arguing for OR against this view. Support your view with reasons and examples. (about 400 words) BOLD = <i>persuasive language</i> <u>Underlined</u> = <i>linking words and signals</i>.

Social Media: More Harm Than Good The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media. That time could have been spent sleeping, revising or simply talking to family. Social media is now ubiquitous, and <u>although</u> it promises connection, it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another. I firmly believe that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. <u>First and foremost</u>, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health. Platforms are designed to reward comparison, <u>so</u> users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's holidays and achievements, and pushed to measure their own lives against them. The evidence is no longer in doubt: according to the US Surgeon General's 2023 advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety. Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates anxiety — harm that is easy to miss <u>because</u> it feels normal.	Title Introduction • Hook • Stance Body 1 - Argument • Topic sentence • Explanation • Example • Round off Body 2 - Argument • Topic sentence
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<u>Moreover</u>, the damage reaches beyond feelings into academic performance. Every notification leaves attention fragmented, making deep reading almost impossible to sustain. Late-night scrolling also delays sleep, <u>which in turn</u> undermines concentration in class. Governments have reached the same conclusion: France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a “digital pause”, requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. When the loss is measured in attention and sleep, convenience is a poor defence. <u>Some may argue that</u> social media keeps teenagers connected and gives them a voice they would otherwise lack. <u>Admittedly</u>, a group chat can help a class organise a project, and a niche interest may find community online. <u>However</u>, these benefits are superficial when set against the costs. Connectivity available at any hour is precisely what makes it hard to switch off, and a following built on ‘likes’ is rarely mutual support; at best, it is a short-lived substitute for friendship. <u>Put simply</u>, the convenience is real but modest, <u>while</u> the harm compounds year after year. <u>In conclusion</u>, social media is not without value, <u>yet</u> its effects on teenagers’ well-being, concentration and self-image plainly outweigh its benefits. Banning the technology would be counterproductive; the answer is a deliberate effort to curb the hours we spend online. If teenagers can learn to switch off, they will discover that the world beyond the screen deserves their attention. (400 words)	• Explanation • Example • Round off Body 3 - Counter-argument • Concede • Rebut • Round off Conclusion • Restate stance • Summarise arguments • Final thought
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5. Language features – five reminders
<i>Both examples in each pair say the SAME thing. BOLD = persuasive language. Underlined = linking words.</i>

Reminder	✗ Poor example	✓ Upgraded example (from the sample)
Formal vocabulary <i>no “super”, “stuff”, “a lot of things”</i>	Social media <u>makes teenagers feel more worried</u> .	Social media exacerbates the anxiety teenagers already carry.
Passive voice ... be + past participle	Teenagers <u>always see</u> the perfect lives of other people on social media.	Teenagers are constantly exposed to polished images of other people’s lives on social media.
Persuasive language (BOLD)	Social media is <u>bad</u> for students.	Social media is detrimental to teenagers’ mental health. Fragmented attention makes deep reading

		<u>almost impossible to sustain.</u>
Linking words <i>(underlined)</i>	Social media is harmful. Students cannot concentrate.	Social media is harmful; <u>as a result</u> , students can no longer concentrate.
Avoid personal pronouns 'you'	You can see that phones are super bad for students' focus.	<u>It is undeniable that</u> over-reliance on smartphones <u>undermines</u> students' concentration.

6. Quick reference — linking words (underlined in the sample)	
Introduce and take a stance	In recent years, ... has become ubiquitous. I firmly believe that ... It is undeniable that ...
Open the first argument	First and foremost, ... The most serious consequence of ... is ...
Add an argument	Moreover, ... Worse still, ... Equally worrying is ...
Give an example	For instance, ... According to + [source] + ([year]), ... Consider what happens when ...
Concede, then rebut	Admittedly, ... Some may argue that ... However, ... What this overlooks is ...
Conclude and end	In conclusion, ... On balance, ... The answer is not to ... but to ...